

DAVID YARROW/TUSK VIA AP IMAGES

HOME GROUND
A cheetah prowls the Namib desert in Namibia

put the brakes on it in 2013, saying such a project would be "arbitrary and illegal". The Union government appealed the SC again and in January 2020 got a go-ahead. After an assessment of 10 habitat options, including Kuno Palpur, Gandhi Sagar Sanctuary in MP and Kota in Rajasthan, the Wildlife Institute of India (WII) found Kuno to be the best option. And experts from South Africa and Namibia who visited the reserve recently have ratified the assessment.

The enclosure at Kuno has been stocked with cheetah food—sambar, spotted deer, wild boar, Indian gazelle and blue bull. "We can augment the prey base as and when required," says Amritanshu Singh, SDO (sub-divisional officer) Kuno. Qatar Airways will fly in the first lot of cheetahs from Windhoek in Namibia to New Delhi, from where the animals will be taken to Kuno by road. However, amid the general excitement about the project, considering this will be the first inter-continental translocation of cheetahs in the world, there's no dearth of serious doubters.

Many among the conservation fraternity who are opposed to the introduction of cheetahs claim that Kuno has an inadequate prey base and is not an ideal habitat for the species. Wildlife conservationist Valmik Thapar has vociferously opposed the plan, arguing that while African cheetahs can be made to stay in fenced areas, possibly being fed by hand or baiting, their usual habitat—the large, open grasslands of Africa—is missing in India. Moreover, he argues that funds being spent on the cheetah could have been used to conserve species at risk, such as the tiger, lion and elephant.

"After seeing 400 different cheetahs in Africa and studying them minutely, I can say that I have not seen any habitat in India that has the prey to support free-ranging cheetah," says Thapar. "Even those who argue that there were cheetahs in India say that they were Asiatic cheetahs. What are being brought in are African cheetahs and therefore exotic species," he adds. Thapar says that the African cheetah, while a graceful animal, is extremely fragile. "Even in the eastern Serengeti, with one million to 1.5 million prey animals for the cheetah, the mortality rate of cheetah cubs is 90 per cent," he argues. And Kuno, he points out, has villages and an abundance of feral dogs all around it.

On the other side of the debate are conservationists such as M.K. Ranjitsinh, a former chairman of the Wildlife Trust of India, who argues that cheetahs are not alien to India. "If Humayun brought the cheetah to India, then what explains its depiction on millennia-old rock art? Also, Akbar had over 1,000 cheetahs. They must have run a very successful conservation/ breeding programme for such an increase," says he. "Kuno is a grassland-forest mosaic...cheetahs are known to survive in forests too. The last cheetah to be shot in India, in modern-day Chhattisgarh, was in a Sal forest," adds Ranjitsinh, who was appointed head of the expert committee to oversee the cheetah translocation by the apex court.

"Kuno has about 30 chital per sq km, a density that rivals many tiger reserves...there are also nilgai, sambar, peafowl, wild pigs and hare, enough for around 20 cheetahs," says Y.V. Jhala, dean, Wildlife Institute of India, Dehradun. "Kuno doesn't have feral dogs and no villages in the 750 sq km area.... Our population viability assessment suggests that the translocation has a high probability of success in the long term. The Cheetah Action Plan has factored in all the doubts," he adds.

"Project Cheetah aims to bring back the only large mammal to go extinct in independent India," Bhupender Yadav says. The Cheetah Action Plan, he adds, will restore the balance of the grasslands that cheetahs once inhabited, conserve biodiversity and harness their ability to sequester carbon to their maximum potential, while promoting ecotourism. A leopard, we know, never changes its spots. Will the African cheetah blend his with the new environs? ■